

MENGRU WANG

Department of Economics, National University of Singapore
+65 8032 7119 · mengruwang@u.nus.edu · mengruwang-econ.github.io

Updated September 2026

Fields of Interest

Research: Economic History, Political Economy, Development Economics

Teaching: Microeconomics, Game Theory, Economic History, Chinese Economy

Education

National University of Singapore, Singapore

Aug 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Ph.D. in Economics

University of Chicago, Chicago, United States

Sep 2018 – Jun 2019

Master of Arts in Social Sciences (MAPSS, Economics Concentration)

Peking University, Beijing, China

Sep 2014 – Jul 2018

Bachelor of Economics in Finance (Yuanpei College, Guanghua Track)

Bachelor of Science in Mathematics and Applied Mathematics

Working Papers

Boundary Manipulation in Qing China's Administrative Hierarchy [*Job Market Paper*]

Abstract: How do states draw their administrative boundaries? While geography offers a natural template for administrative division, boundaries are often manipulated to serve political ends. This paper examines boundary manipulation across the administrative hierarchy of Qing China (1644–1911), comparing the provincial and prefectural boundaries of 1820 with hypothetical units constructed from geographical attributes. At the provincial level, I confirm the deliberate manipulation documented in the literature, with the most misaligned provinces lying along the Qinling–Huaihe divide between north and south China. At the prefectural level, I find no evidence of manipulation, as misalignment is spatially diffuse and reflects physiography rather than strategy. The provincial manipulation, moreover, did not penetrate downward, as it operated by reallocating intact prefectures rather than redrawing their boundaries. These findings reveal a tradeoff in boundary design between political stability and administrative efficiency, with the state securing control at the top of the hierarchy while preserving geographical coherence below.

When Peace Made the State: Song China in Comparative Perspective (*with Tuan-Hwee Sng and Shengyi Zhang, draft in preparation*)

Summary: We model two components of state capacity, fiscal reach and military coordination, and use the model to explain the different institutional choices of Song and Qing China. In our model, the ruler chooses between two administrative structures: an inspectorate, in which middle-tier officials only monitor and handle neither revenue nor troops, and a governorship, in which they collect revenue and command troops but can turn that command against the ruler. We show that the inspectorate raises total tax collection but cannot coordinate military power, while the governorship raises military power at the cost of tax collection. The ruler's choice of administrative structure depends on how he perceives the internal and external threats. A ruler who fears usurpation from within chooses the inspectorate and gives up military capacity, as the Song did; a ruler who needs more deployable power against an external threat chooses the governorship and gives up fiscal reach, as the Qing did. These findings help to explain the paradox of Song China, a state with deep fiscal reach but weak military coordination, as opposed to early modern European states in which fiscal and military capacity reinforced each other.

Work in Progress

A Tale of Two Rivers (*with Youhong Lin and Tuan-Hwee Sng*)

Research Experience

Harvard Business School, Boston, United States

Aug 2019 – Jun 2021

Full-time Research Associate for Prof. Laura Alfaro

- Lead research associate on *Omnia Juncta in Uno: Foreign Powers and Trademark Protection in Shanghai's Concession Era* (L. Alfaro, G. Bao, M. Chen, J. Hong, C. Steinwender), studying how legal institutions shaped firm behavior in early twentieth-century Shanghai; additional analyses for Prof. Alfaro's other projects
- Data: cleaning and managing the Shanghai Hong List panel from digitized records; refining firm matching across years and sources; resolving data-quality problems in a reproducible workflow
- Estimation: implementing difference-in-differences, triple-difference, and event-study designs; conducting robustness checks including pre-trend tests, heterogeneity analyses, and alternative specifications
- Delivery: presenting the results to the faculty team every week; producing all tables and figures for the paper

Peking University, Beijing, China

Feb 2017 – Jul 2017

Part-time Research Assistant for Prof. Chong Liu

Conferences and Workshops

Presenter, The 12th Annual Symposium on Quantitative History

Jul 2026

Presenter, The 12th Hong Kong Economic Association Biennial Conference

Jun 2026

Participant, The 8th Asian Historical Economics Conference

Dec 2024

Participant, The 9th Summer School for Quantitative History

Jul 2023

Academic Service

Referee for *Explorations in Economic History* (2 reports), *Economic Systems* (3 reports)

2024 – 2026

Student Facilitator, The 3rd Conference on New Economic History of China

Mar 2026

Teaching Experience

TA, NUS Economics Department Ph.D. Math Camp (taught by faculty from 2026)

Summer 2026

TA, HS2909 The Rise and Fall and Rise of China, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng

Fall 2025

TA, HS2909 The Rise and Fall and Rise of China, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng

Spring 2025

TA, EC3312 Game Theory & Applications to Economics, with Prof. Sam Jindani

Fall 2024

Tutor, Yale-NUS Economics Capstone Program

2024 – 2025

Instructor, NUS Economics Department Ph.D. Math Camp

Summer 2024

TA, EC3101 Microeconomic Analysis II, with Dr. Timothy Wong

Spring 2024

TA, EC3101 Microeconomic Analysis II, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng

Spring 2023

Awards & Scholarships

K.R. Chou PhD Scholarship in Economics, National University of Singapore

2025

Research Scholarship, National University of Singapore

2021 – 2025

Outstanding Graduate, Peking University

2018

Guanghua Scholarship, Peking University

2017, 2018

Li Huirong Scholarship, Peking University

2015, 2016

Miscellaneous

Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, ArcGIS, L^AT_EX

Languages: English (fluent), Mandarin (native)

Citizenship: China

References

Tuan-Hwee Sng (Thesis Advisor)

Department of Economics, National University of Singapore

Email: tsng@nus.edu.sg

David S. Jacks (Committee Member)

Department of Economics, National University of Singapore

Email: dsjacks@nus.edu.sg

Siddharth Eapen George (Committee Member)

Department of Economics, National University of Singapore

Email: segeorge@nus.edu.sg